FLEET TEAM DIGEST

737MAX-FTD-32-17014

Issue Title : Loss of Nose Wheel Steering Due to Ice On Steering Cable Control System

Airplane Model	ATA	Minor Model(s)
737MAX	3250-00	-7, -8, -8200, -9, -BBJ

Other Model(s)	ECCN
737	9E991

Originated Date	Last Revised Date	Created On
05/02/2017	05/02/2017	04/21/2017

Estimated Completion Date	Next Update Date

Applicability

All airplanes operating in extreme cold weather environments.

Description

A small number of 737 operators have reported difficulties steering the airplane with the nose wheel steering system after landing in very cold environments. In most cases, the problem has been attributed to ice accumulation in the nose wheel well due to unusually severe freezing rain conditions where movement of the steering cables or pulleys became restricted.

In most of the cases, the steering control was only partially affected and was cleared by flight crew use of the tiller to break away the ice build-up. In severe cases, the ice needed to be cleared by ground personnel after the airplane came to a stop.

However, there have been a small number of cases on 737NG airplanes where the problem was caused by accumulation of water inside the lower nose compartment, just outboard of the left nose gear trunnion (where the steering cables pass through the trunnion at BS 291). In these cases, the water came from a leak in one of the forward lavatory or waste drain hoses that went undetected until enough water accumulated in the fuselage to freeze the steering cables and pulleys. See photo. In these cases, the airplanes were being operated in extremely cold environments.

Status

Closed.

Interim Action

N/A

Final Action

We recommend the following actions to help reduce the likelihood of frozen steering cables due to lavatory or galley leakage:

1) Examine of all forward lavatory, galley drain, and potable water tubes and hoses for general condition and security, loose clamps, chafing, split hoses, and leaks. It is important to verify clamp tightness as their security can relax over time. We recommend that this check is done periodically (such as annually) prior to the beginning of winter operations, especially if the operator flies into unusually cold environments.

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2) Ensure that there is a water drain path around the insulation blankets directly below the steering cables and pulley bracket. This will help prevent accumulation of water around the steering components.

3) At convenient maintenance opportunities during winter operations, open the left aft nose gear wheel well sidewall access panel and check for signs of water accumulation at the steering cable pulley bracket.

4) Ensure that all potable water and waste drain lines are drained whenever the airplane will be left unattended for long periods of time as specified in AMM 12-33-02/301.

5) Consider replacing hoses at suspect areas periodically, based on operator experience.

6) For airplanes that operate continuously in extreme cold weather, put the airplane into a heated hangar periodically to thaw the insulation blankets and other equipment and allow the melted ice to drain away.

Reference Categories

Reference Type	Reference Number	Revision Number	Reference Date
Aircraft Maintenance Manual (AMM)	12-33-02/301		
Aircraft Maintenance Manual (AMM)	12-14-01/301		
Aircraft Maintenance Manual (AMM)	12-17-01/301		

Related Categories

- Airplane Maintenance Issues : Issues that occur during airplane maintenance or have an impact on airplane reliability
- Fleet Team IdeaXchange : Topic of discussion on the Fleet Team IdeaXchange bulletin board
- In Service Occurrences : null

Attachments:

a) Torn Drain Hose

b) Ice Accumulation on Steering Cables

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